understanding and cooperative relations with each other. Both President Gotabaya Rajapaksa and Prime Minister Mahinda Rajapaksa paid official visits to India in 2019 and 2020, respectively. It, however, remains to be seen to what extent they will accommodate India's concerns on bilateral issues, as well as the implications of China's growing presence in Sri Lanka. In Bangladesh, India has quietly lent full support to the Awami League government headed by Sheikh Hasina Wajid in the 2019 elections. India generally ignored overtures made by the opposition groups led by the BNP to distance itself from the Awami League. Fortunately for India, the Awami League registered a sweeping victory, and it is hoped that cooperation and overall strategic understanding between the two countries will progress smoothly in the coming years. India also had to redefine its approach to the question of Rohingya migrants from Myanmar into Bangladesh to reassure Bangladesh of its support. Now India has to alleviate Bangladesh's apprehensions arising out of India's domestic political agenda on citizenship issues.

To take its outreach beyond the power elites to the popular level, India has further stepped up its use of soft power, including the revival of religious and civilisational links. A great deal of emphasis has been placed on Buddhism in this respect, as this also seeks to counter the Chinese strategy to appropriate the Buddhist legacy and undermine the importance of the Dalai Lama of Tibet, who is living in India with a large number of his followers.[23] India is persuading Nepal to go slow on Chinese collaboration for developing Lumbini by offering its support. India has joined hands with Japan to mobilise the World Buddhist Forum. It has hosted four international gatherings on Buddhism in Bodh Gaya (2015), Varanasi (2016), Rajgir (2017), and New Delhi (2018). Efforts are being made to strengthen Nalanda University and develop Buddhist pilgrimage circuits in the